



Panama Canal

An engineering marvel, a shortcut between the oceans completed at an enormous human cost



△ LATER ADDITIONS

The 51-mile- (82-km-) long Panama Canal was expanded in 2016 and new locks were added. These can handle ships three times the size of the older locks.

The narrow isthmus of Panama that separates the Atlantic Ocean from the Pacific was long an impediment to shipping. Dangerous voyages south, around Cape Horn, deterred all but the most hardy travelers and traders. Then, French engineers, emboldened by their successful construction of the Suez Canal connecting the Mediterranean to the Red Sea, began to build a similar waterway across the Panama isthmus in 1880. However, work stopped when engineering problems and high worker mortality contributed to the bankruptcy of the construction company in 1889.

Gargantuan labors

Undaunted, the US—the country with the most to gain from such a canal—took over the project in 1904. Over the next decade, workers carved out more than 4.5 billion cubic ft (130 million cubic m) of rock and earth, creating what was then the largest man-made lake in the world—Gatún Lake—to feed the locks at either side. The new canal was an instant success, with around 350 vessels using it in 1914, its first year of operation.

THE ROUTE OF THE CANAL

Ships entering the Panama Canal from the Caribbean Sea in the north approach across Limon Bay. They then rise 85 ft (26 m) up the Gatún Locks into the inland Gatún Lake, passing through the Gaillard Cut and then descending through more locks into the Pacific Ocean next to Panama City. New sets of locks were opened at either end in 2016 to cater to larger ships.

